

Class 3: Toward a Pursuit of Joy



Start with this video: (You can increase the speed of the video if you would like)

📺 First 55 min. up to slide 18.mp4

Last 5 minutes : 📺 slide 18-21.mp4

498 Non-Negotiables: Our Collective Agreement for Online Etiquette

For detailed description of each agreements click here

1. Remember that everyone has been through their own challenges, and that emotion/passion is not the same as weakness/irrationality. Be considerate of others and understand that they are trying to engage with you and your culture, so you should respectfully attempt to do the same. *Staying committed to shared understanding
2. Engage constructively with others online as you would with people in person; with respect, kindness, and empathy.
3. Use technology meaningfully and responsibly, ensuring that you are aware of the strengths and limitations of your digital resources.
4. Value the other person's contributions online by considering time and be as respectful as you would in real life interactions.
5. Ensure your face is in full frame and that you do not have any distracting backgrounds or visual effects enabled. Be present to the fullest extent possible, as though you were in an in-person setting.
6. Make contributions with informed foundations from depth of practice and research and participate with critical thinking. It's okay to be unfamiliar with a topic; that's the point of learning, continue leverage cultural resources in the community

7. Accept that disagreements and discomfort will occur, and advocate for open and respectful communication. Experiencing discomfort and conflict helps us to grow as learners.
8. Respect other people's privacy and do not share personal information that others shared during the class. Focus on the lesson, not the story
9. Be mindful of your own privilege and power; do not weaponize it but use it to uplift others by listening, respecting differences of opinion (as they TOO can be right) and make space for everyone to contribute.
10. Approach the mistakes, yours and your peers, with empathy and openness; to be human is to make mistakes. Recognize in these moments opportunities for growth, deeper understanding of ourselves, our community and the topics we are tackling.

Class objectives:
Engage with Joyful Literacy Practices: We will reflect on and explore personal and collective experiences with joyful literacy practices, applying these insights to deepen our understanding of how joy can enhance literacy engagement and learning. Apply Culturally and Historically Responsive Pedagogy: We will critically engage with course readings and discussions on joyful literacy, examining how culturally and historically responsive practices can foster joy and hope in literacy instruction. Create, Reflect, and Share: We will participate in hands-on activities from the Joyful Literacy Pursuit Choice Board, create reflective content, and contribute to a collective journal to share insights, celebrate learning, and foster a supportive learning community.

Starting with Wellness: Tapping into Your Joy		
Name	What are joyful literacy practices for you?	When was the last time you

	Be specific.	engaged in that practice? Why ?
Alyse	I love listening to audio books that I have already read and journaling. My mind wanders a bit, I get curious, go off on a tangent of thought and wind up thinking about something in a whole new way. Some of my best thinking and writing starts in these moments.	It has been a few weeks since I have been able to engage in this practice. I had some academic writing deadlines and grades for the spring semester so I had less time recently to read for pleasure.
Sarafina	One of my most exercised joyful literary practices is reading fiction. I read historical romance paired with “who- done- its” and murder mysteries. I watch the same genres as well in film. I mostly read on my phone but every once in a while, I'll read via an actual paperback book. My physical state does affect what vehicle I choose to read on; paperback or via a device. I find that I choose based on my eye comfort, the state of my hands (if they feel tight or not) and the location I find myself in which can influence the ease of access to the book or device.	I engaged in this practice just last night before bed. I engage in this practice every night before bed. At this point in my life its become a part of my routine reading, especially fiction, before bed. It's a bit of enjoyment before I close my eyes and dream. I often find that themes in the books influence my dreams which take me on a fun journey and thats always something to get excited about and to look forward to.
Christina	I love curling up with a book from my “to be read” list on either my couch or reading chair with a glass of milk and cookies. I would read for a couple of hours straight and not take a break unless it was to use the bathroom or get more food	I haven't had a chance to do this for about two months. I've been busy with school and work (now grad school) and every weekend seems to get booked up by something. But I am very lucky that this upcoming weekend I have no plans...it's time to hit the couch!
Emma	I love sitting outside in the afternoon when I get home from work and reading a good fiction book to wind down. If it's not nice enough outside, I like to sit by the window with the natural light coming in. Sometimes I'll get myself a nice cool drink to sip on too.	I haven't been able to do this in a few weeks because I've been busy moving into my new apartment, work, and homework. I'm excited to get a chance to do this more though with the weather getting nicer and my new place has a front porch that is very cozy and perfect for quiet reading.

Anvitha	A joyful literacy practice for me is starting my morning with a fresh cup of coffee, some soft background music, and at least an hour of reading a fiction book. If I'm feeling extra ambitious, I will use my Kindle and knit a simple project at the same time as reading the book, which really gets me to a state of total focus and meditation, in a way.	The last time I was able to find time for this was back in winter break, so back in January. I am always, always consumed with work and can hardly find time/energy to do regular chores, let alone leisure time! Warner keeps me so busy...
Zoe	My joyful literacy practice is having a day off, no worries, no stress, to lie in bed or on the couch and read all day. I love romance novels that mix history or create an entirely different world system. If I get caught on it, I could spend the whole day reading.	I remember those days more clearly when I was on summer break during my freshman or sophomore year of undergrad, or in high school. I miss those days dearly, but nowadays I have so many things to do every day that I barely have time to read something only for pleasure.
Piter	My joyful literacy practices live at the intersection of research, identity, and code. I find deep joy in my quantum computing work — building algorithms and exploring problems that push the boundary of what computation can mean. I also find joy in fairness-centered data science work — using literacy and research to challenge bias and advocate for equity. Beyond technical work, I find joy in expressive, identity-driven journals and reflective writing — spaces where my multiple identities (neurodivergent, Latino, bilingual, educator, researcher) can show up fully without being flattened. These include trauma-informed teaching reflections, AI in education journals, self-portrait writing, and equity-focused research like my EQUITAS framework. For me, joyful literacy is active creation, analysis, and advocacy across code, writing, and scholarship.	I engage in these practices continuously — they are woven into my daily work. My quantum and fairness research are live, ongoing projects. My teaching journals connect directly to my IGNITE placement at Pine Brook, where I bring these same lenses into a K–12 CS classroom every week. The reason I keep returning to them is because they are the spaces where I feel most like myself; where my thinking is recognized as thinking, not reduced to a format that does not fit who I am.
Zach	My joyful literary practice is to go somewhere quiet and outdoors with a book of poetry (or something else that encourages me to read slowly). I like to set up for an hour or two and spend some time reading and using what I find in the reading to process whatever is happening in my life at that moment.	I haven't been able to practice this in a while, at least a couple months. Life has been so busy lately that I've let some of these slower habits fall to the wayside. I'm hoping that I'll be able to find more time for this as the summer begins.
Alyssa	One of my favorite literacy practices started	The last time I engaged with this

	in high school; I took an approx. five-year hiatus in elementary/middle school from television because I loved reading so much. Since high school, I have loved sitting down and reading Japanese manga or watching anime as a way to keep up my Japanese language skills and relax from a stressful or busy day doing something that is calm and enjoyable. Genre-wise I am pretty much all over the place, but I prefer fictional readings/viewings more than anything (and that's always been my preference).	was last night or the night before. I try to get in one chapter of a manga and/or episode of an anime each day because that takes me approximately 20-30 minutes to do so. I have found this helpful, as it is my way of prepping before I go to bed. It lets me end the night positively by giving me the chance to leisurely practice my Japanese language skills and have a jumping-off point to have interesting and bizarre dreams.
Chase	I enjoy writing in a journal sometimes when I have too many thoughts to keep track of. Sometimes I will go back and re-read things I put down and then reflect on them. Another practice I enjoy is reading random things I see out in public from billboards to trash on the ground. I like to think about how or why those things are there and about what kind of impacts they have on life.	The last time I journaled was a couple nights ago. It was because I had encountered many different people at work, heard many unique stories and feedback, and wanted to write them down so that if I forgot in my head, I could always look back. I also feel like writing fresh memories down helps me remember them in more detail. As for reading random things outside, definitely today. For example, the grocery store, and I did a lot of commodity label reading because I was curious about where some things came from.

Digging In:

List at least one strong theme you were seeing across the readings:

Examples:

Joyful literacy, and the broader role of joy in education, has historical roots dating back to the 1700s; however, these approaches have largely been overshadowed by contemporary standardized curriculum models.

Incorporating joy into the curriculum involves more than simply providing students with enjoyable resources; it also includes exposing learners to diverse narratives, perspectives, and meaningful forms of engagement.

Christina: Examining on a surface level, joyful literacy can motivate students in school and benefit their academic work. However, going deeper into the literature, joyful literacy can be taken outside of the classroom and can sculpt the way students interact with the world.

Sarafina: Joy, being student-centered in all that we do as educators, was a consistent theme across all of the readings. Most curriculums are additive or contribution focused. These types of framings are limiting as they are standardized-focused and fail to center joy in the curriculum. When Joy is centered, through types of curriculum like Transformation and Social Action, it looks like but is not limited to collective collaboration and authentic problem-solving that develops consciousness and leads to enlightenment which affects social change and makes lives better.

Anvitha: Joy has a very strong connection to justice; when dealing with hardships, embracing joyful literacy can help students fight against issues that have meaning to them while increasing self-awareness and intellect.

Emma: Joy is an important and serious part of learning. It's not something extra or separate from education. Joyful literacy experiences can emerge through creativity, collaboration, relationships, storytelling, and meaningful interactions with others and the environment. Literacy development is stronger when students feel engaged, connected, and emotionally invested in what they're doing. It makes learning more memorable and meaningful.

Piter: Joy in literacy depends on recognition and access. Students may already be doing rich literacy work through debugging, designing, explaining, collaborating, and revising, but that joy becomes invisible when schools only count traditional forms of reading and writing. A joyful literacy classroom must be designed so students' strengths have real pathways in, and so their multimodal thinking is noticed, valued, and documented.

Zoe: Joy is more than happiness or celebration. It is a fundamental pursuit in literacy that creates better spaces for students to learn. It is a different and revolutionary perspective that is well-connected to criticality and social justice.

Zach: Joy necessitates an active pursuit of social justice and healing. A practice that ignores or contributes to social harm cannot be rooted in joy. And a practice that is not rooted in joy will likely lack the stamina necessary to continue in perpetuity.

Alyssa: Joy in literacy is liberatory. By this I mean wielding joy into a tool is essential in having a positive relationship with oneself, others, and one's literacy journey (in general). Joy in literacy can be implemented at any time throughout one's education and in an abundance of ways, but it is also a collective/collaborative tool, making it all the more impactful.

Chase: Joy is universal, but not homogeneous. To elaborate, it is found all throughout the world, in every classroom, but is not experienced or reflected the same by every person. Classes are heterogeneous, and all people, their lived stories and contributions are as well.

Discussion Bank

1. What's the difference between happiness and joy in school? Why does it matter?
2. How can we tell when joy is actually happening in our classrooms, and how do we respond when it's missing?
3. What are some real examples of joy unfolding in the classroom, especially through things like books, materials, or student relationships?
4. Why should we start lessons or read-alouds with joy instead of focusing on hard or painful topics first?
5. How can we show or model joy for students even when we're feeling tired, stressed, or overwhelmed?
6. Why do so many of the readings link joy in literacy with race and justice? What happens if we ignore that connection?
7. How can things like art, music, and student interests bring more joy into literacy learning?
8. What does it look like for teachers to be more than just 'skills instructors'? How does joy fit into that role?
9. What would need to change in teacher prep or schools for joy to be taken as seriously as other learning goals?

Connect 1 or 2 questions from the discussion bank to your theme found in this week's readings and further explore each question, document your thinking below
Make at least one connection to someone else's post using the comment feature.

Name : Christina

Connections : Question 2→ The article “Unfolding joy in young children’s literacy practices in a Finnish early years classroom” had a prime example of what joy looks like in the classroom. The article talks about a child who has been working on their storybook with little guidance from the teacher. One student finished his book and looked at it with a smile, calmly stating that his book was done. The child then takes the book and hugs it to his chest, overcome with joy at what he has just created. If we were to reflect on our journey through education, was there ever a time where you had to take a moment and bask in what you had learned or created? I feel for myself that this has happened recently. Through my grad readings, I am finding so many connections from

	undergrad that it makes me stop and acknowledge to the world “I’ve been on the right track!” From articles and books I’ve read to work experiences, I feel elated by the experiences I have collected over the past four years, and I want to keep reading and learning to see where the other connections are. Cultivating joy in primary and secondary school will keep children wanting to learn, to always find another connection to what they have learned previously. Having joy in what you’re learning makes every task more enjoyable, even when it is hard, because you want to know where it goes from here. I think, for educators, if we notice a lack of joy in the classroom with the materials, we should reconnect with what makes them the happiest. Maybe taking a survey at the beginning of the school year, so you know ahead of time, and completing that activity as a reset. It could also be a good idea to think outside of the box for assignments and structure it to fit the students’ interests.
Name : Anvitha	Connections : Responding to Question 6 – Joy, as part of the culturally and historically responsive framework, is derived from the real struggles and oppression of our ancestors. Without acknowledging the history of our practices and discussing how our actions today relate to the actions of those before us, classroom knowledge becomes isolated from students’ cultural and community funds of knowledge. Students won’t see how the emotions and skills they cultivate in the classroom connect to their identities or the identities of those around them. As educators, I think we have the responsibility to show students that knowledge doesn’t just exist on its own, it is generated from real collaboration and passed through generations using literacy practices like reading, writing, and storytelling. This relates to the reading on Activating Joy: “Joy is situated well in the culturally and historically responsive framework because as students are learning joy, they should also learn about how they are, about the cultural lives of diverse people, new skills, and a justice orientated education.” (p. 122) I also think about how humans pursue things that are grueling and challenging because the feeling of achievement and growing as a person is a joyful experience. Without the struggle, the feeling of joy does not hold much meaning, so we should always teach this in context.
Name : Zoe	Connections : Regarding Question 1, when I first started the readings, especially with Unearthing Joy, I had made the same wrongly assumption that happiness and joy were

	synonyms. I mean, they could be, but in this framework Joy is so much more. I think joy does include moments of happiness in the classroom but joy in the classroom has a purpose. I quoted this part from the readings in this week's discussion board, which I think clarifies the differences between happiness and joy. "Joy is fun and celebratory, yet it is <u>not only about having fun and celebrating</u> in schools and classrooms (although that is important). It is also the embodiment of, <u>learning of, and practice of love of self and humanity</u>, and <u>care for and help for humanity</u> and the earth. Joy encompasses happiness/smiles, truth, beauty, aesthetics, art, wonder, personal fulfillment, and solutions to the social problems of the world". After better understanding what joy means, I think it is crucial that we implement it in our future (or current for some) classrooms. Teaching literacy with joy can be transformative, it can improve the reception and engagement of students with content and it can still make a fun and creative space while dealing with important social problems of the world, but not only problems, but also celebrating diversity and joyful literacy practices. I personally loved the examples provided in the Activating Joy through Read-alouds reading.
Name : Sarafina	Connections : Question 2: How can we tell when joy is actually happening in our classrooms, and how do we respond when it's missing? Reading the text <i>Unfolding joy in young children's literacy practices in a Finnish early years classroom</i> was very heartwarming and a genuine example of witnessing joy blossom before an educator's eye. Reading about the student Viggo and his careful attention to storybooking shows how joy unfolds through enthusiasm, dedication, claiming ownership and even smiles. This was an activity that Viggo wanted to do even when the learning session was over. I would say the lack of these markers is when we can tell that joy is missing from the classroom. Students eagerly leave the activity right when the learning session ends, there are no requests for more: more time on the activity, more sessions to do the activity again or more materials to recreate the activity on their own time. There are also no follow up questions showing engagement with the activity and that is because no meaningful connection was formed. The students might not

	care where their activity ends up on a wall or in a bin because they don't claim ownership of their work as something worth holding on to or to be proud of. They view their work as just an assignment which makes it easy for them to let go of or even to forget that they did it. Question 5: How can we show or model joy for students even when we're feeling tired, stressed, or overwhelmed? This is such a down to earth question because as much as society calls teachers superheroes, they are also human too. Acknowledging that one is human and thus fallible is an important first step. The next step is to realize that not everything is the end of the world. There is almost always a way to make up for a mistake or to make things better. Knowing that there is hope is what makes tense moments feel like there is room to overcome and do better. Relating this question to one of the take-aways from the reading text is that teachers are learners too. Infact, according to the Culturally and Historically Responsive Education framework it is the responsibility of the teacher to continually better themselves and that will in turn aid in the instruction and assistance to their students. Joy feels like wholeness and is empowering and healing. What this means is that teachers have a duty to find and center joy in their own lives and education. When centering joy becomes a continuous practice even when a teacher may feel tired, stressed or overwhelmed they can draw energy and recharge from that which brings them joy. I think that amazing ability to recharge from joy is part of why society views teachers as superheroes.
Name : Emma	Connections : Question 8: What does it look like for teachers to be more than just 'skills instructors'? How does joy fit into that role? For teachers to be more than “skill instructors,” they need to be able to design learning experiences that center in identity, connection, creativity, and meaning. In the article, “Unfolding joy in young children’s literacy practices in a Finnish early years classroom,” the example of Viggo and the Storybook helps make this idea very concrete. Instead of focusing on teaching discrete reading or writing skills, the teacher is involved in creating a space where literacy emerges through making, feeling, and interacting with materials. In the Storybook project, the teacher’s role isn’t to correct or direct Viggo’s literacy learning. Instead, it’s important to support a multimodal, open-ended process. The teacher provides resources (paper, markers, magazines, clay, etc.), guides the structure of the project and offers encouragement,

	but the most important part is leaving significant space for the child to make their own meaning. This shifts the teacher's role from instructor to facilitator. The teacher is not primarily focused on whether Viggo has mastered a specific literacy benchmark, instead, she's supporting participation, creativity, expression, and engagement across multiple modes. In this example, joy is not an "extra" outcome, it's part of the learning process itself.
Name : Piter	Connections : Q3 — At Pine Brook Elementary, Spring 2026, I saw joy unfold three ways. In Kindergarten, I redesigned a squishy circuits lesson so students built a fan circuit together as a team — one contributor per table, supported by their group, counting down and throwing the switch together. The fan turned on. That collective ownership was joy. The airplane build that followed worked because belonging came first. In Grade 4 Minecraft, a student who finished early became a peer teacher — his classmate broke through because of him. That shared payoff, <i>"Out of here you go, baby!"</i> is joy through relationships. A third student spent forty minutes resetting a timed puzzle, failing, adjusting, and trying again until it worked. Joy earned through persistence, not compliance. All three fit Muhammad's argument: joy must be designed for, not assumed. Q8 — The squishy circuits lesson was a redesign decision. The original plan was a standard demo — I transmit, students receive, then replicate. I changed it: contributor roles by table, vocabulary named only when students had it in their hands, mistakes corrected by peers not by me, shared understanding built before anyone worked independently. Muhammad says teachers must <i>create the conditions</i> for joy, not produce it. A skills instructor shows the fan on minute one. I showed it on minute fifteen, after every student had a hand in the circuit. That is the difference.
Name : Zach	Connections : Question 5 - Joy does not negate or even necessarily overcome feelings of stress or sadness. Rather, it gives us space to examine those feelings without losing sight of hope. As educators, we should never be handing our students the emotional burden of working through our own personal feelings, but it can be helpful for students to see and understand that these feelings are natural, especially when dealing in critical work, but ultimately joy prevails. Consider how the Youth Equity Agents project helped give youth tools to first process painful issues in their own community and then to confront them with actionable work. The researcher noted how it was important to not move past negative student experiences and to understand that not every student will respond in the same way to this kind of work. Question 6 - Joy must confront and seek to redress harm, and

	at the same time joy must seek to understand others. This is as true in literacy as it is in any other discipline. Muhammad notes, “joy cannot be embraced fully if oppression is present” (Unearthing Joy, 15). How can we expect students to respond joyfully to our teaching if we are actively ignoring their lived experiences, positive and negative? A joyful community must reflect all of its inhabitants and their identities. In this way, joyfulness and criticality go hand in hand. Criticality without joyfulness is bound to lead to burnout and joyfulness without criticality is hollow.
Name : Alyssa	Connections : Question 2: As I identified joy as a liberatory tool in the previous task, I feel like we can tell that joy is actually happening in our classrooms when students feel empowered to speak out more often, challenge their own beliefs (and respectfully challenge others’), and feel free to express their own unique identities both inside and outside of the classroom. This can show itself in a multitude of ways, but I think one big one is a rise in student participation/discussion and students feeling more comfortable discussing elements of themselves they may have never expressed before. As for how to respond when this is missing, I would say giving students more time to self-reflect during class, whether this be a journal entry they anonymously submit at the end of each week, or raising classroom discussions that give students the opportunity to do some of the things I listed above. Also, educators being more personal (not too personal of course), will encourage students into doing the same. Exemplifying joy will hopefully help students subconsciously start to do the same (i.e. leading by example is a possible solution).
Name : Chase	Connections : Q4- Why should we start lessons or read-alouds with joy instead of focusing on hard or painful topics first? There are endless answers to this question because joy encompasses many unique hardships. I for one believe that joy can intertwine with struggle though. While it is of course important to make students feel a sense of excitement to get energized before starting a lesson, there are far deeper nuances. To set the scene for a solid example, text from one of our readings states, “Joy is also recognizing the truth and voices of people who have been marginalized and historically excluded.” (Vlach, et. al, pp. 121). (A good one for Q6 as well,) This quote emphasizes that joy is uplifting the voices tangled in deep roots of historical injustice. Therefore, you

	never want to set the scene for a certain person(s), place(s) or period with pain. That initial tone can make people associate their own connections or relation to said topics/discussions in ways that may overlook the fact that although human lived experience may be full of suffering, there is much more to it, such as the passion and resilience beyond pain that acts as the impetus for stories of social justice and joy to be shared (through literacy, for example) for generations to come.
Name :	Connections :

Break: 6:00- 6:15



Digging Deeper :

 **Week 3- The Importance of Joy in Literacy Instruction.pptx-3.pdf**

Commitment
is what transforms
a promise into reality.
—Abraham Lincoln

Commit to one joyful literacy pursuit that you will intentionally incorporate into your mini-unit. This can be revised later as your plans evolve, but consider it your first step toward designing with purpose and joy at the center of your final project.

Joy can and should be an educational pursuit, where we ask ourselves:

How does my curriculum and instruction enable, amplify, and spread joy (any type of joy)?

What types of joy could I bring into the curriculum and instruction?

How does my curriculum and instruction elevate beauty within humanity?

How will I write learning objectives that will help my students pursue and embrace joy?

How will I know if my students are experiencing the learning practices of joy?

Name: Christina R.W.

Commitment: One question that has stood out to me concerns the types of joy I can bring to the curriculum and instruction. Everyone has their own way of processing information and things that they are good at. For educators, it's important to leverage our students' strengths, especially when topics may be harder to understand. At the beginning of the school year, I would pass out a survey to learn a little bit more about what my students are interested in and what they feel they are good at. I would do my best to interweave their interests into my curriculum planning. Because, at the end of the day, this is their education, and they have a right to decide how they can learn that suits them best. It is my job as an educator to facilitate their knowledge and help guide them on their journey.

Name: Anvitha Shoroff

Commitment: One joyful literacy pursuit I will commit to is spending at least one class of my mini-unit in an outdoor setting. I think this is a meaningful practice because it can quite literally ground students in the science happening all around them while giving students space to breathe and think freely. This would be a good place for everyone to create their own artifacts representing anything we covered during the school year that they enjoyed or found interesting.

Name: Sarafina

Commitment: A joyful literacy pursuit that I want to commit to in my literary unit is examining either short literary text like a poem, song, dialogue or quote, and uncovering its meaning. This pursuit is very multifaceted and I feel like that's what makes it so engaging because there isn't one correct answer. The students can draw on their own experiences and name what they feel from the words and how they make sense of the text.

Name: Zach

Commitment: I will commit to at least one activity in my mini-unit that allows students to find and share a piece of poetry that brings them joy. I believe this will encourage students to share joy and think creatively about our unit, while giving them space to make it their own.

Name: Zoe

Commitment: As a future foreign language teacher, I will commit to include joy in the appreciation of diverse cultures and something that connects most humans; music! One of the joyful learning practices that I remember vividly from when I was a foreign language student was my English teacher playing a Coldplay song (Viva la vida) and we would fill in the blanks with what we thought we heard. It was such a joyful and rewarding moment when all of us connected to the beautiful meaning of a song, as well as actively learning vocabulary and understanding of the language. I want to present a weekly fun activity that involves music from different Hispanic authors, and I would also love to explain how different cultures and instruments all over the world helped shape latino music. That way students can also feel connected in their identity and understand the global share of community and culture.

Name: Piter

Commitment: My joyful literacy pursuit for the mini-unit is *belonging before building*. Before any student works independently or in a group, the whole class will build shared understanding together through a *contributor + team model*: one student per table as the contributor, supported by their group, with vocabulary and concepts named only once students have the materials in their hands. Joy is not added on top of the lesson; it is the structure of the lesson itself. Janet Jackson's *State of the World* asks who is being left out and why that is acceptable. My mini-unit brings that same question to literacy instruction, because joy that is not structurally accessible is not available to all students. Joy in that *literary work* is not just celebration; it is a demand. It is what joy looks like when connected to justice, and that is the frame this mini-unit commits to.

Name: Emma

Commitment: One joyful literacy pursuit that I want to commit to is offering a choice on how each student wants to learn. I would like to offer an opportunity to make a skit/video, write a song, make a drawing/poster, etc. about what they are learning. The value of choice is so important because it automatically gets students to think about what they want to do and motivates them to create that vision.

Name: Alyssa

Commitment: Since my mini-unit will be centred around ELOne joyful literacy pursuit that I would like to incorporate into my mini-unit

Name: Chase

Commitment: A joyful literacy pursuit that I would like to commit to is asking students to express something about themselves or life that gives them joy. I will offer a variety of options to be creative with, such as writing, drawing, recording, or digital creation. I will especially encourage the use of real world examples to intertwine with projects (such as music or pictures).

Name:

Commitment:

Asynchronous Activity Instructions:

Directions: Select an activity from the joyful literacy pursuit choice board that you would like to engage in or choose your own (add it to the board as a future option). Engage in the activity and then reflect on the experience by completing a journal (visual, audio, written) share your journal below as with you to class on Thursday next week.

Joyful Literacy Pursuit Choice Board

Play some guitar No instrument no problem: https://www.musicca.com/guitar	Engage in a play or reading a play or watching a play or live theater	Begin/continue a YA novel reading at least 1 chapter (kindle offers tons of free content)	Write a letter to a friend/penpal
Listen to music in a foreign language	Explore how a song is sung / composed	Read something adapted for film or from film	Read up or listen to some current events
Create/cut Music	Create a discipline specific music parody	Listen to music and read about the making of that music	Read a memoir Get inspired here
Journal (you won't have to share this entry)	Share a book review you write with a friend as a way to entice them to read with you	Explore ways to build content with others (music, poetry, plays, scary stories) Hitrecord.com	Create a piece of art of your choosing and reflect on why you did
Read a peer reviewed journal in your discipline https://scholar.google.com/	Listen at least a chapter of an audio book (Audible offers many classics free of charge and tons of promos for content too)	Do something sciency - experiment but do not blow anything up!	Code something, create an algorithm, engage in some maths
Take a book out into nature and read and connect	Pick up a childhood favorite book and read some of it again - explore how your thoughts on the book have changed or stayed the same	Learn a new dance or reconnect with a style of dance you have not engaged with in a while.	Explore a new or favorite story driven game and see if there any nuances you missed before or interesting narratives you'd like to explore more

New Entry	New Entry	New Entry	New Entry
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Share your Joyful Journal Here
Name: Christina R.W. Journal Entry: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1p_YSCjl5pwjU_UA8nm0C03QO50mTEqcCRtiSds81KJI/edit?usp=sharing
Name: Sarafina Journal Entry: I listened to Yemi Alade's song Na Gode featuring Selebobo, which is in the Hausa and Igbo languages peppered with some Pidgin English. She also does a Swahili version. This song brings good vibes just from the rhythms, cadence, and the sweetness of her voice. The instrumental is uplifting and pairs perfectly with the lyrics which are meant to be inspirational. Yemi talks about lessons which celebrate life like showing gratitude when you are winning and even when you aren't. She sings about how we all face challenges but that it's important to keep fighting to overcome them because it is in us to drive our own fates and achieve our dreams. I remember hearing this song for the first time when I was a volunteer teaching in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania. The instrumental and Yemi's words still evoke the same feelings of self worth in me. It also generates a warmth that I think comes from being energized by her song. This is how joy as a literary pursuit works. Joy is inspiring and it makes an impression. Even almost a decade after my service trip, I still connect to the beauty of this song because of the happiness and sense of liberation it instills in me. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=a8dqVuHmj5k&list=RDa8dqVuHmj5k&start_radio=1
Name: Anvitha Journal Entry: Link to Journal Entry
Name: Emma Journal Entry: I reread part of the book series that I was obsessed with in third grade. It's called <i>Warriors</i>, and it's about clans of wild cats living in a forest. I still have a lot of the first few books because I loved them so much, and this was such a crazy throwback for me. Part of me is impressed with myself that I read about 30 of these books in one year at the age of 8. The writing is definitely a bit more juvenile than what I read now, but I didn't find it boring. Maybe it's nostalgia but I found myself being drawn back into the story again. My understanding of the characters is a little different now, and I understood some plot points a little better than I did when I first read these books. I really enjoyed this exercise and although I probably won't finish the book, it was really fun to revisit something that was such a big part of my childhood and remember who I was when I first read it.
Name: Alyssa

Journal Entry:

Name: Piter

Choice Board Activity: Code something, create an algorithm, engage in some maths

Artifact: [EQUITAS Healthcare AI Fairness Unit Master.ipynb](#)

Journal Entry:

For my joyful literacy pursuit, I chose to code an interactive Colab notebook built around healthcare AI fairness. This was joyful not because of the coding part, but because I was designing a learning experience through code and literature. Every decision required me to think about how students would read the page, move through activities, interpret visuals, respond to fairness scenarios, and make meaning from systems that affect real lives.

This connects directly to my mini-unit commitment of *belonging before building*. The notebook gives learners a structured pathway into difficult ideas before asking them to produce independently. Coding here was a literacy practice because I was using language, structure, visuals, interaction, and feedback to make complex ideas accessible. The joy came from building something that invites students into the learning rather than leaving them outside of it, which is the same demand Janet Jackson's *State of the World* makes of the systems that shape people's lives.

Joy that is not structurally accessible is not available to all students. This notebook is my attempt to design for that.

Name: Chase

Journal Entry: I went outside to read a book that I have actually been trying to finish for over a year now. This book is called *1491* by Charles C. Mann. I can remember reading it outside the most last summer when I was lifeguarding a lot. I read it a bit more when bored during planning periods for subbing, but I never really got much through it this year. It is a dense book, and it makes me want to google things every page, which can be annoying. However, I feel obligated to finish this book. Despite reading some other things in between periods of not even thinking about this book, a part of me always knows that it will always be there haunting me until I finish it. After all, it is a good book, and everyone who is familiar with it says the same to me. This was a great distraction from reading up on current events!

Name:

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Looking Forward:

Class 4: Cultural Pedagogies

Muhammad, G. (2020). Chapter 2. pp. 38-61.

Paris, D., & Alim, H. S. (2014). What are we seeking to sustain through culturally sustaining pedagogy? A loving critique forward. *Harvard Educational Review*, 84(1), 85-100.

Strekalova-Hughes, E., & Wang, X. C. (2019). Perspectives of children from refugee backgrounds on their family storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice. *Journal of Research in Childhood Education*, 33(1), 6-21.

Ladson-Billings, G. (2021). Three Decades of Culturally Relevant, Responsive, & Sustaining Pedagogy: What Lies Ahead? *The Educational Forum*, 85(4), 351–354.

Watch:

Gorman, A. (2021, January 20). *The hill we climb*. [Video]. The Guardian. (5:43)

Truth, Love & Racial Literacy 2022. Yolanda Sealey-Ruiz discusses the power of racial literacy development, and why truth, love, and an Archaeology of Self are required when educating Black and Brown students.